(including in cooperation with the Zamorin of Calicut). [64] But Portuguese maritime dominance was eventually undermined by the gradual entry into the Indian Ocean of the Dutch, English, French, and Danes.

Except for the Portuguese, who early on claimed imperial rights in India, other Europeans arrived primarily as traders. By the mid-1600s, the English, Portuguese, Dutch, Danes, and French were competing for favour in the Mughal court. It would be ‘a good thing to try to remove from the mind of Aurangzeb and the ministers every ground for fearing that we would one day be too powerful in these regions’, the French traveller and physician Francois Bernier wrote from India, adding ominously, ‘It is not yet the time.’ [65] But while various Indian kingdoms and empires—the Marathas, Sikhs, Rajputs, and Mysore—jostled for control of India during the vacuum left by the Mughals in the eighteenth century, so did the Europeans. In was in this environment that the East India Company—a private but state-backed corporation—arose as the leading colonial power in India, paving the way for British rule.

The East India Company was established in 1600 by royal charter and private financing, initially with an eye on the spice trade in today’s Indonesia. Its first flotilla of four ships set sail from England in 1601, and next year after stops in South Africa, Madagascar, and the Nicobar Islands, it arrived in Aceh, where it found ‘Gujeratis’, people of ‘Bengal’, and ‘Malibaris’ already engaged in trading activities. Trading posts called ‘factories’ (led by ‘factors’) were soon established with a regional base in Bantam in Java in 1617. Despite the company’s charter initially making no mention of territorial control, they focused on Pulo Ai and Pulo Run, two tiny islands in the Moluccas covered in nutmeg trees. (King James I later even styled himself the King of ‘Puloway and Puloroon’, marking some of the first British imperial claims in Asia. [66]) It was only after failures in present-day Indonesia, where the English were eventually ousted by the Dutch—as well as in Japan and Siam—that the Company turned its attention to today’s India.

The English commercial presence in India had two rather separate origins. On the east coast, factories emerged as an outgrowth of the